

NEW WORLDS

Product Vision & Session Notes

Developed with Clu (Claude) — March 2026

The Idea in One Breath

Liner notes made interactive and navigable.

New Worlds is a music experience app that makes listening feel like holding a record. Album-centric, immersive, and built around the connections between artists, studios, and labels — the context that streaming stripped away.

Brand

Name

New Worlds

Emerged organically during the session — not a description of the app, but a description of the feeling. The moment a new artist or song genuinely stops you. That feeling is the product.

Tagline

Follow the rabbit hole.

Simple, evocative, doesn't mention music. Works as both navigation metaphor and brand promise.

Core Interaction Name

Expansion

The moment a node pulls to center and the entire map reorients around it. Not about the app shifting — about the user expanding. Every click grows your world.

Brand Rallying Cry

Reject the Algorithm.

T-shirt and sticker material. Confrontational, universally understood, doesn't need to name Spotify. Positions New Worlds not as anti-tech but as pro-human — curation and provenance over algorithmic consumption.

Product Philosophy

The Core Thesis

Music is one giant connected thing. New Worlds makes those connections visible and beautiful.

What Makes It Different

- Streaming apps optimize for engagement and retention — keeping you on platform consuming
- New Worlds optimizes for discovery and understanding — it's okay if you leave to buy a record or go to a show
- Spotify flattened music into context-free soup. New Worlds restores provenance — everything has a where, a when, a who
- Label pages don't exist on Spotify. Labels are the original curators — 4AD in 1992 was a playlist
- The algorithm can't understand why Drag City artists share an ethos, not just a genre

The Vinyl Resurgence Connection

The vinyl resurgence isn't really about sound quality — it's about wanting music to mean something again. New Worlds is that feeling, native to the web instead of a record shelf.

Design Language

Visual Direction

- Dark, desaturated UI — lets album art do all the talking
- Album art as full-screen immersive backdrop
- Typography: clean, confident hierarchy — similar to Damien Jurado prototype screens
- Noise texture overlay for warmth and analog feel

Three Screens Designed

- Album Detail View — tracklist, liner notes tab, album lyrics tab, label info, producer credits, release date. The record sleeve made digital
- Artist Albums View — grid of album art, chronological, art-first. Like pulling an artist's section from the crates
- Orbital / Related Artists View — the signature screen. Artist at center, collaborators in orbit by proximity and relevance

Node Visual Differentiation

Three distinct visual treatments for node types on the orbital screen:

- Artists — circles with photos

- Studios — architectural, location-feel, pin or building shape
- Labels — graphic, logo-forward

Node type answers: what is this? Orbit level answers: how deep am I? Together they give the user full spatial orientation.

Information Architecture Principle

Weighted detail by orbit — closer to the source, more apparent. Move outward and it becomes increasingly tangential and sparse.

The outer ring nodes being sparse isn't a bug — it's the design. Incompleteness mirrors how music knowledge actually works. You know everything about your favorite band, less and less as you move outward.

The Expansion Interaction

- Orbital rings can be rotated while interacting
 - Proximity = detail — nodes closer to center show richer info
 - Hover or dwell — rest on a node and it blooms open with label, role, key release
 - Click = Expansion — node pulls to center, entire map reorients. Deerhunter becomes the sun. New nodes appear
 - The trail — subtle breadcrumb of where you've been. The journey itself becomes shareable
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Data Model

Core Node Types

- Artist — full band or solo artist
- Band — side project or collaborative band
- Label — record label, connective tissue between artists
- Engineer / Producer — the hands that shaped the sound
- Studio — the physical place, location node
- Influence — connected but not directly

Edge / Relationship Types

- Member — person is in this band
- Collaborated — direct creative collaboration or guest appearance
- Engineered / Produced — technical/creative role on a record
- Recorded At — session at a specific studio
- Signed To / Released On — label relationship
- Founded — artist founded this label or studio
- Scene — shared scene, city, or era connection
- Leads To — discovery path, follow this thread

Orbit Levels

- Level 0 — Center node (the anchor band)
- Level 1 — Direct members, own label, closest collaborators. What a fan knows
- Level 2 — Scene, studios, engineers, key connections. What an obsessive knows
- Level 3 — One hop from collaborators, deeper label web. What New Worlds reveals
- Level 4 — Deep cuts, discovery nodes
- Level 5 — Follow any thread far enough

The Studio/Producer Insight

Studios and producers are first-class nodes — not metadata. This unlocks the most powerful discovery chains. Electrical Audio alone connects Ty Segall to Nirvana to PJ Harvey to Jesus Lizard to Godspeed You! Black Emperor. These artists aren't genre-related — they're philosophically related through a person and a place.

Seed Dataset — Ty Segall

Why Ty Segall

- Prolific — 17+ solo albums plus multiple side projects (Fuzz, GØGGS, Wasted Shirt)
- Rich collaborator web — Mikal Cronin, Charles Moothart, White Fence, Emmett Kelly
- Multiple label connections — Drag City, In The Red Records, Castle Face Records
- Steve Albini engineered his 2017 self-titled — the Albini thread opens a vast world
- Accessible enough to demo without intimidating — riff-heavy, melodic records
- You'll listen to him constantly while building — the right energy

The Albini Thread

Steve Albini as a Level 2 node is the most powerful thread in the dataset. His engineering credits alone connect: Pixies (Surfer Rosa), PJ Harvey (Rid of Me), Nirvana (In Utero), Jesus Lizard (Goat), Godspeed You! Black Emperor, Low, The Breeders, Cloud Nothings, Mclusky, Songs: Ohia, Neurosis, Slint.

Crucially — these artists don't share a genre. They share a philosophy. Albini believed records should sound like a band in a room. That values alignment is what the orbital screen reveals that no algorithm can.

The Drag City Thread

Drag City as a Level 1 label node connects Ty to: Bill Callahan (formerly Smog), Joanna Newsom, Bonnie Prince Billy (Will Oldham), Ryley Walker. Follow that label and you have a masterclass in a certain strand of American independent music from 1989 to now.

Deliverables

- Knowledge graph spreadsheet — Ty Segall centered, 35+ nodes, 36+ edges, fully typed and orbit-leveled

- Available as: new_worlds_knowledge_graph_ty_segall.xlsx
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Build Strategy

Approach

- Manual curation for proof of concept — quality over completeness
- Start with Ty Segall cluster, prove the concept, then expand to other satellites
- HTML/CSS/JS prototype — existing 2024 codebase (Loveless / My Bloody Valentine) to be revived and evolved
- No AI generates music — this is a human curation and experience design problem, not an AI problem

Tech Stack Instincts

- WebSockets / real-time presence — Supabase or Pusher for future social layer
- Music licensing — embed Spotify/Apple Music/YouTube players, own the experience layer
- Data — MusicBrainz and Discogs as starting points, heavily supplemented by manual curation
- The orbital UI — D3.js or Three.js for the interactive graph

MVP Principle

The smallest version that still makes someone's jaw drop.

Build the orbital screen first. Ty Segall at center, inner ring only, spinning interaction. Static data. Doesn't need to play music yet. Nail the Expansion moment. Then layer outward.

Learning Path (Revised)

Original question was: what AI course to take? Answer after this session: for New Worlds specifically, AI is a minimal component. The real stack to learn:

- D3.js or similar for the force-directed graph / orbital UI
- Music licensing landscape — how to embed without owning
- MusicBrainz API — what data exists, what needs manual curation
- Real-time presence (for eventual social layer) — Supabase

For general AI strategy: Andrew Ng's AI for Everyone (Coursera) + Generative AI with LLMs (DeepLearning.AI) remain the right starting points — but build in parallel, don't wait to feel ready.

Key Phrases from the Session

Follow the rabbit hole.

Expansion.

New Worlds.

Reject the Algorithm.

Liner notes made interactive and navigable.

The app isn't the gatekeeper. You become your own gatekeeper.

The map looks completely different depending on where you enter.

Music is one giant connected thing. New Worlds makes those threads visible and beautiful.

Feelings lead to names.

Session with Clu (Claude Sonnet 4.6) — March 2026. Started as an AI course question. Ended with a product name.